

thebigschmooze (TBS)

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Basics

What is the big schmooze (TBS)?

TBS is a new, fun, and easy way for busy people to communicate, keep in touch, get opinions, collaborate, and stay connected with the friends, family, or colleagues. Form your group, set a topic, ask a question or leave it open. We will call this a “topic,” and the aggregated responses to it a “schmooze”. When they have a moment, everyone in your group chimes in with their audio message which can be an answer to your question or a little personal journal or a comment or whatever they like. (We can think of some interesting creative possibilities, like putting a song together where everyone sings one line!)

When enough people have responded or when the deadline is up, TBS stitches all of these responses together into an audio file, a “schmooze” which anyone in the group can listen to whenever they like via the app, or download and listen to like a podcast. The first version of the app will keep it simple, and simply put these together in the order they come in, with a header note (the question/topic itself) and a short note between each message... “John Smith, on Monday at 8 PM said...”

Why do we need this and who would use it?

In the modern world it is hard to maintain relationships and have meaningful conversations and discussions. Families and friends are spread out around the world, and everyone has a different schedule. We all have a different times that we feel like talking. Some people are morning larks and others are night owls. We also have different times that we want to talk about different sorts of topics. Sometimes you feel like talking about something serious, sometimes we just want to laugh. There are many people so busy that they don’t have time to chat except when doing something else like driving or washing the dishes. And then there’s the problem of time zones.

A key goal of TBS is to “shift time”: to bring together Johnny during his Saturday morning walk when he feels like telling the story of his exciting surfing

trip to Indonesia with Mary on her long Monday morning commute when she feels like listening to a cool story. Or bringing together a group of college friends are now split between London and Los Angeles, and who want to share their opinions about sports and politics over a drink at happy hour. Lots of us now spend hours each week immersed in podcasts, many of which are audio diaries and opinions and stories from complete strangers. (See the “earbuds” documentary). This is fun, comforting, and something to do to make sure and commuting more entertaining. It even can give you the feeling that you are not alone, and you are part of a social circle. But is not the same thing as a conversation with your actual friends and family.

But aren’t we already doing this (Facebook, Snapchat, Twitter, Skype, WhatsApp,...)?

Not really. On Facebook we are posting short messages and sometimes even videos but we are not really having personal conversations. Facebook really is not the “Thanksgiving dinner table Conversation” or “deep late-night chat at at the pub”.

We can leave audio and video messages on our phones, on Skype, and on things like Snapchat, but this disjointed and not done and organised way. If you want to hear personal stories about what your family is up to, in their own words and *with their own voices*, and listen to this while eating your meal, waiting in line at the airport, or working out, there is no easy hands-free way to do it. And there is no way to organise a good conversation over a particular topic.

How will groups be formed and administered?

Anyone can start a group and invite people, and/or specify rules for who can join. To get this started, we can work with other social media platforms and with Gmail (this problem has been solved in many contexts).

The founder of each group can also set rules over who can post questions, and how many questions everyone can post per week. They can also set rules about how many responses you must give in order to be allowed to list the question, and we can introduce rating tools. These ratings may be used to assign priority in the schmooze (whose response is first, who gets how much time, etc).

Planned updates

Future updates of the app will include features such as allowing you to vote up or down each response, and allow each member to select which group members they want to hear the response from and in what order. We also envision

“public schmoozes” where anyone in the world, or in the company or university is allowed to contribute, and the group leader works with the app to stitch together only the best responses. We will also work to incorporate other media features, allowing you to put in background music, sound effects, and pictures or videos.

But for now let’s keep it simple.

How can this be “monetised”?

You are so Shallow! Always thinking about money, when we are trying to bring people together here.

Okay, this can be profitable. For successful apps, there is always a chance that it may be purchased and integrated into other platforms and hardware. Leaving this aside, We see several opportunities for filthy lucre:

1. The app can include visual (and sparingly, audio) advertisements that play while people are listening to a schmooze. This can be well targeted based on the composition of the group and the topics they discuss. For example, political ads could be targeted at groups consisting of important “swing” demographics that discuss key issues where opinions and votes are malleable, or where turnout is particularly important. Similarly, groups that talk about new technology and gadgets may be easily targeted for these products.
2. Further advertising and promotional content could be included in content (like “public schmoozes”, Podcasts, and other shows) that are built based from this platform.
3. TBS will be used by professional work groups; we can charge these businesses and employers for premium features, like the ability to offer rewards and prizes for the most helpful schmoozers, and to do particular analytics on the audio content.
4. Consumer facing businesses, media providers, and political issue groups want to attract participants to their own schmooze groups. They will want to offer rewards, and we will be able to charge them to help them build their membership.

Technology we need to build or access

- Social media platform to allow people to find their friends and make and administer groups

- This should include the “find my friends on Facebook, through email, etc.” feature
- Interface for mobile phones (And computers)
 - buttons and text interface to join and access groups and play and skip through schmoozes
 - Voice recognition and talking interface to do this hands-free (may have to wait for a later update if we could not find a plug in technology)
- Tool for users to record (and potentially edit) and upload messages
- To organise these message files and stitch them together into an audio (Schmooze) file
- To insert “tag” content between each file (“John Smith said, on Wednesday at 10:30”)
 - Breaks in the file to allow listeners to skip through the elements